

LIFE CHANGES EARTH TO ITS OWN PURPOSES

THE GAIA HYPOTHESIS

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

James Lovelock (1919–2022)

BEFORE

1935 British botanist Arthur Tansley uses “ecosystem” to describe an interdependent community of biological and nonbiological components.

1953 In *Fundamentals of Ecology*, American ecologist Eugene Odum describes Earth as a collection of interlocking ecosystems.

AFTER

1985 In the US, the first conference on the Gaia hypothesis is held, entitled, “Is the Earth a Living Organism?”

2004 James Lovelock voices his support for nuclear power over renewable energy.

In 1979, British scientist James Lovelock’s book *Gaia: A New Look at Life on Earth* presented his Gaia hypothesis to a general readership. In essence, Lovelock claimed that Earth is a single, self-regulating system, in which living and nonliving elements combine to promote life. The book quickly became a bestseller, and caught the imagination of the growing Green movement, offering a fresh approach to environmentalism.